Ulrich Jasper Seetzen — Reisen durch Syrien, Palästina, Phönicien, die Transjordan-Länder, Arabia Petraea und Unter-Aegypten

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Ulrich Jasper Seetzen of Jever (1767–1811), found dead two days after leaving Mocha in September 1811, allegedly poisoned on the orders of the imam of Sanaa. Many of his papers never reached Europe, and his diary waited more than forty years for print. Edward Robinson, in 1841, called him “judicious, enterprising and indefatigable.”

The story

Seetzen was born on 30 January 1767 at Jever, in German Frisia. At Göttingen he graduated in medicine. In 1802 he took a government post at Jever, but was drawn to exploration. That summer he set out down the Danube, and after six months in Constantinople he reached Aleppo, where he remained from November 1803 to April 1805 studying Arabic.

His chief exploit was a tour round the Dead Sea, made alone in the disguise of a beggar. From Egypt he went by sea to Jeddah and reached Mecca as a pilgrim in October 1809, under the name Musa al-Hakim. He travelled from Medina to

Aden and returned to Mokha, in Yemen, from where he wrote his last letters in November 1810. In September 1811 he left Mocha hoping to reach Muscat, but was found dead two days later, allegedly poisoned by his guides on orders from the imam of Sanaa. A scholarly treatment cited in the notes calls the circumstances “never clarified” and records a rival rumour of marauders. Many of his papers never reached Europe; the collections saved form the Oriental museum and the chief part of the Oriental manuscripts at Gotha.

The work and what survives

The *Reisen* is the posthumous diary of his travels of 1802–1811, edited by Fr. Kruse and others and printed at Berlin by G. Reimer. Volumes 1 and 2 appeared in 1854 and volume 3 in 1855; only volume 4, the *Commentare*, is of 1859.

This project holds two slices of it, in fresh English renderings from the German of the 1854 edition, each a local draft awaiting its final checks. By diary order the first is volume 1, printed pages 396–432: the Transjordan circuit of 13 March to 10 April 1806, the final leg of a longer Damascus run round the Dead Sea, taking in Amman, Kerak, and the sea's southern end — 12,259 words in its file. The second is volume 2, printed pages 217–236: Bethlehem to Ein Gedi on 15–16 December 1806, the opening of the west-side Dead Sea journey — 7,394 words. The second folder warns that the diaries reached print through other men's hands, so Kruse's work is “both a help and a warning.”

Its English fortunes

No English translation of the *Reisen,* in whole or of either slice held here, was found after research.

It is not a claim to be the first English Seetzen. The one historical English Seetzen book, *A Brief Account of the Countries Adjoining the Lake of Tiberias, the Jordan, and the Dead Sea* (London, 1810), is not a translation of the *Reisen*, which it predates by forty-four years. The second folder describes his English afterlife, in its own words, as “reduced for generations” to that pamphlet; that phrase is the folder's wording only, not this edition's claim. The check of 16 October 2026 did not search union catalogues, nor the nineteenth-century Palestine literature for short translated excerpts; the finding stands at that

bound.

What completing it would take

The two slices must stand as one edition, in diary order as here, even though the volume 2 slice was drafted first. Both folders say the final place-name, biographical, and dedication-gate checks are undone; the second folder's place-name list, giving Ain Dschíddy as Ein Gedi, is a starting apparatus, not a verified one. Continuation, if ordered, follows the folders' map: finish the west-side journey (volume 2, pages 236–274), then the east-side second journey (pages 293–385), and, behind the volume 1 slice, its earlier legs (pages 312–396). One record item stays open: the folder names are crossed against the titles they contain — volume 1, pages 396–432, titled “The Transjordan Circuit,” sits in the `seetzen-dead-sea-diaries` folder, and volume 2, pages 217–236, titled “The Dead Sea Journey,” sits in the `seetzen-arabian-diaries` folder. Neither is Arabian in content, so citation stays by volume and pages, never by folder name alone.

Sources

- Project folders: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/seetzen-dead-sea-diaries/seetzen-dead-sea-diaries.txt` (volume 1 slice); `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/seetzen-arabian-diaries/seetzen-arabian-diaries.txt` (volume 2 slice)
- PIN: `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-seetzen.md`
- Ulrich Jasper Seetzen, biographical and bibliographical record: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ulrich_Jasper_Seetzen
- Norbert Nebes, “Ulrich Jasper Seetzen im Jemen,” as cited in the PIN: https://journals.uco.es/mediterranea/article/download/16623/16136/49880